The Ancient World

The Bible, 1 Samuel

(ca. 960 B.C.E.)

Saul was the first king of Israel, reigning between roughly 1020 and 1000 B.C.E. Comparatively little is known about his reign, though he was renowned for leading the Israelites in war against their enemies the Philistines. The Bible devotes a great deal of time to recounting Saul's jealousy of and conflict with his son-in-law and future successor, David. The extent to which the account in Samuel is accurate is, at the very least, difficult to assess. From the standpoint of the history of madness, however, the story of Saul's erratic behavior and his volatile relationship with David provides a glimpse into how the ancient Israelites recognized there to be links and boundaries between religious experience and madness. As the text repeats several times, "Is Saul also among the prophets?"

1 Samuel 10

1 Then Samuel took a vial of oil and poured it on his [Saul's] head, and kissed him and said, "Has not the LORD anointed you to be prince over his people Israel? And you shall reign over the people of the LORD and you will save them from the hand of their enemies round about. And this shall be the sign to you that the LORD has anointed you to be prince over his heritage.

2 When you depart from me today you will meet two men by Rachel's
tomb in the territory of Benjamin at Zelzah, and they will say to you,
'The asses which you went to seek are found, and now your father has
ceased to care about the asses and is anxious about you, saying, "What
shall I do about my son?"'
3 Then you shall go on from there further and come to the oak of Tabor;
three men going up to God at Bethel will meet you there, one carrying
three kids, another carrying three loaves of bread, and another carry-
ing a skin of wine.
4 And they will greet you and give you two loaves of bread, which you
shall accept from their hand.
5 After that you shall come to Gib'e-ath-elo'him, where there is a garri-
son of the Philistines; and there, as you come to the city, you will meet
a band of prophets coming down from the high place with harp, tam-
bourine, flute, and lyre before them, prophesying.
6 Then the spirit of the LORD will come mightily upon you, and you
shall prophesy with them and be turned into another man.
7 Now when these signs meet you, do whatever your hand finds to do,
for God is with you.
8 And you shall go down before me to Gilgal; and behold, I am coming to
you to offer burnt offerings and to sacrifice peace offerings. Seven days
you shall wait, until I come to you and show you what you shall do."
9 When he turned his back to leave Samuel, God gave him another
heart; and all these signs came to pass that day.
10 When they came to Gib'e-ah, behold, a band of prophets met him; and
the spirit of God came mightily upon him, and he prophesied among
them.
11 And when all who knew him before saw how he prophesied with the
prophets, the people said to one another, "What has come over the
son of Kish? Is Saul also among the prophets?"
12 And a man of the place answered, "And who is their father?" There-
fore it became a proverb, "Is Saul also among the prophets?"

1 Samuel 15

1 And Samuel said to Saul, "The LORD sent me to anoint you king over
his people Israel; now therefore hearken to the words of the LORD.

2 Thus says the LORD of hosts, 'I will punish what Am'alek did to Israel
in opposing them on the way, when they came up out of Egypt.
3 Now go and smite Am'alek, and utterly destroy all that they have; do
not spare them, but kill both man and woman, infant and suckling, ox
and sheep, camel and ass.'"
4 So Saul summoned the people, and numbered them in Tela'im, two
hundred thousand men on foot, and ten thousand men of Judah.
5 And Saul came to the city of Am'alek, and lay in wait in the valley.
6 And Saul said to the Ken'ites, "Go, depart, go down from among the
Amal'ekites, lest I destroy you with them; for you showed kindness to
all the people of Israel when they came up out of Egypt." So the
Ken'ites departed from among the Amal'ekites.
7 And Saul defeated the Amal'ekites, from Hav'ilah as far as Shur, which
is east of Egypt.
8 And he took Agag the king of the Amal'ekites alive, and utterly
destroyed all the people with the edge of the sword.
9 But Saul and the people spared Agag, and the best of the sheep and of
the oxen and of the fatlings, and the lambs, and all that was good, and
would not utterly destroy them; all that was despised and worthless
they utterly destroyed.
10 The word of the LORD came to Samuel:
11 "I repent that I have made Saul king; for he has turned back from fol-
lowing me, and has not performed my commandments." And Samuel
was angry; and he cried to the LORD all night.
12 And Samuel rose early to meet Saul in the morning; and it was told
Samuel, "Saul came to Carmel, and behold, he set up a monument for
himself and turned, and passed on, and went down to Gilgal."
13 And Samuel came to Saul, and Saul said to him, "Blessed be you to the
LORD; I have performed the commandment of the LORD."
14 And Samuel said, "What then is this bleating of the sheep in my ears,
and the lowing of the oxen which I hear?"
15 Saul said, "They have brought them from the Amal'ekites; for the peo-
ple spared the best of the sheep and of the oxen, to sacrifice to the
LORD your God; and the rest we have utterly destroyed."
16 Then Samuel said to Saul, "Stop! I will tell you what the LORD said to
me this night." And he said to him, "Say on."
17 And Samuel said, "Though you are little in your own eyes, are you not

the head of the tribes of Israel? The LORD anointed you king over Israel.
18 And the LORD sent you on a mission, and said, 'Go, utterly destroy the sinners, the Amal'ekites, and fight against them until they are consumed.'
19 Why then did you not obey the voice of the LORD? Why did you swoop on the spoil, and do what was evil in the sight of the LORD?"
20 And Saul said to Samuel, "I have obeyed the voice of the LORD, I have gone on the mission on which the LORD sent me, I have brought Agag the king of Am'alek, and I have utterly destroyed the Amal'ekites.
21 But the people took of the spoil, sheep and oxen, the best of the things devoted to destruction, to sacrifice to the LORD your God in Gilgal."
22 And Samuel said, "Has the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams.
23 For rebellion is as the sin of divination, and stubbornness is as iniquity and idolatry. Because you have rejected the word of the LORD, he has also rejected you from being king."
24 And Saul said to Samuel, "I have sinned; for I have transgressed the commandment of the LORD and your words, because I feared the people and obeyed their voice.
25 Now therefore, I pray, pardon my sin, and return with me, that I may worship the LORD."
26 And Samuel said to Saul, "I will not return with you; for you have rejected the word of the LORD, and the LORD has rejected you from being king over Israel."
27 As Samuel turned to go away, Saul laid hold upon the skirt of his robe, and it tore.
28 And Samuel said to him, "The LORD has torn the kingdom of Israel from you this day, and has given it to a neighbor of yours, who is better than you.
29 And also the Glory of Israel will not lie or repent; for he is not a man, that he should repent."
30 Then he said, "I have sinned; yet honor me now before the elders of my people and before Israel, and return with me, that I may worship the LORD your God."
31 So Samuel turned back after Saul; and Saul worshiped the LORD.

32 Then Samuel said, "Bring here to me Agag the king of the
Amal'ekites." And Agag came to him cheerfully. Agag said, "Surely
the bitterness of death is past."
33 And Samuel said, "As your sword has made women childless, so shall
your mother be childless among women." And Samuel hewed Agag in
pieces before the LORD in Gilgal.
34 Then Samuel went to Ramah; and Saul went up to his house in Gib'e-
ah of Saul.
35 And Samuel did not see Saul again until the day of his death, but
Samuel grieved over Saul. And the LORD repented that he had made
Saul king over Israel.

1 Samuel 16

1 The LORD said to Samuel, "How long will you grieve over Saul, seeing
I have rejected him from being king over Israel? Fill your horn with oil,
and go; I will send you to Jesse the Bethlehemite, for I have provided
for myself a king among his sons."
2 And Samuel said, "How can I go? If Saul hears it, he will kill me." And
the LORD said, "Take a heifer with you, and say, 'I have come to sacri-
fice to the LORD.'
3 And invite Jesse to the sacrifice, and I will show you what you shall do;
and you shall anoint for me him whom I name to you."
4 Samuel did what the LORD commanded, and came to Bethlehem. The
elders of the city came to meet him trembling, and said, "Do you come
peaceably?"
5 And he said, "Peaceably; I have come to sacrifice to the LORD; con-
secrate yourselves, and come with me to the sacrifice." And he conse-
crated Jesse and his sons, and invited them to the sacrifice.
6 When they came, he looked on Eli'ab and thought, "Surely the
LORD'S anointed is before him."
7 But the LORD said to Samuel, "Do not look on his appearance or on
the height of his stature, because I have rejected him; for the LORD sees
not as man sees; man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD
looks on the heart."
8 Then Jesse called Abin'adab, and made him pass before Samuel. And
he said, "Neither has the LORD chosen this one."

9 Then Jesse made Shammah pass by. And he said, "Neither has the LORD chosen this one."
10 And Jesse made seven of his sons pass before Samuel. And Samuel said to Jesse, "The LORD has not chosen these."
11 And Samuel said to Jesse, "Are all your sons here?" And he said, "There remains yet the youngest, but behold, he is keeping the sheep." And Samuel said to Jesse, "Send and fetch him; for we will not sit down till he comes here."
12 And he sent, and brought him in. Now he was ruddy, and had beautiful eyes, and was handsome. And the LORD said, "Arise, anoint him; for this is he."
13 Then Samuel took the horn of oil, and anointed him in the midst of his brothers; and the Spirit of the LORD came mightily upon David from that day forward. And Samuel rose up, and went to Ramah.
14 Now the Spirit of the LORD departed from Saul, and an evil spirit from the LORD tormented him.
15 And Saul's servants said to him, "Behold now, an evil spirit from God is tormenting you.
16 Let our lord now command your servants, who are before you, to seek out a man who is skilful in playing the lyre; and when the evil spirit from God is upon you, he will play it, and you will be well."
17 So Saul said to his servants, "Provide for me a man who can play well, and bring him to me."
18 One of the young men answered, "Behold, I have seen a son of Jesse the Bethlehemite, who is skilful in playing, a man of valor, a man of war, prudent in speech, and a man of good presence; and the LORD is with him."
19 Therefore Saul sent messengers to Jesse, and said, "Send me David your son, who is with the sheep."
20 And Jesse took an ass laden with bread, and a skin of wine and a kid, and sent them by David his son to Saul.
21 And David came to Saul, and entered his service. And Saul loved him greatly, and he became his armor-bearer.
22 And Saul sent to Jesse, saying, "Let David remain in my service, for he has found favor in my sight."
23 And whenever the evil spirit from God was upon Saul, David took the lyre and played it with his hand; so Saul was refreshed, and was well, and the evil spirit departed from him.

1 Samuel 18

5 And David went out and was successful wherever Saul sent him; so
that Saul set him over the men of war. And this was good in the sight
of all the people and also in the sight of Saul's servants.
6 As they were coming home, when David returned from slaying the
Philistine, the women came out of all the cities of Israel, singing and
dancing, to meet King Saul, with timbrels, with songs of joy, and with
instruments of music.
7 And the women sang to one another as they made merry, "Saul has
slain his thousands, and David his ten thousands."
8 And Saul was very angry, and this saying displeased him; he said,
"They have ascribed to David ten thousands, and to me they have
ascribed thousands; and what more can he have but the kingdom?"
9 And Saul eyed David from that day on.
10 And on the morrow an evil spirit from God rushed upon Saul, and he
raved within his house, while David was playing the lyre, as he did day
by day. Saul had his spear in his hand;
11 and Saul cast the spear, for he thought, "I will pin David to the wall."
But David evaded him twice.
12 Saul was afraid of David, because the LORD was with him but had
departed from Saul.

1 Samuel 19

9 Then an evil spirit from the LORD came upon Saul, as he sat in his
house with his spear in his hand; and David was playing the lyre.
10 And Saul sought to pin David to the wall with the spear; but he eluded
Saul, so that he struck the spear into the wall. And David fled, and
escaped.
11 That night Saul sent messengers to David's house to watch him, that
he might kill him in the morning. But Michal, David's wife, told him,
"If you do not save your life tonight, tomorrow you will be killed."
12 So Michal let David down through the window; and he fled away and
escaped.
13 Michal took an image and laid it on the bed and put a pillow of goats'
hair at its head, and covered it with the clothes.

14 And when Saul sent messengers to take David, she said, "He is sick."
15 Then Saul sent the messengers to see David, saying, "Bring him up to me in the bed, that I may kill him."
16 And when the messengers came in, behold, the image was in the bed, with the pillow of goats' hair at its head.
17 Saul said to Michal, "Why have you deceived me thus, and let my enemy go, so that he has escaped?" And Michal answered Saul, "He said to me, 'Let me go; why should I kill you?'"
18 Now David fled and escaped, and he came to Samuel at Ramah, and told him all that Saul had done to him. And he and Samuel went and dwelt at Nai'oth.
19 And it was told Saul, "Behold, David is at Nai'oth in Ramah."
20 Then Saul sent messengers to take David; and when they saw the company of the prophets prophesying, and Samuel standing as head over them, the Spirit of God came upon the messengers of Saul, and they also prophesied.
21 When it was told Saul, he sent other messengers, and they also prophesied. And Saul sent messengers again the third time, and they also prophesied.
22 Then he himself went to Ramah, and came to the great well that is in Secu; and he asked, "Where are Samuel and David?" And one said, "Behold, they are at Nai'oth in Ramah."
23 And he went from there to Nai'oth in Ramah; and the Spirit of God came upon him also, and as he went he prophesied, until he came to Nai'oth in Ramah.
24 And he too stripped off his clothes, and he too prophesied before Samuel, and lay naked all that day and all that night. Hence it is said, "Is Saul also among the prophets?"

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Euripides

(484–407/6 B.C.E.)

The Bacchae

(ca. 404 B.C.E.)

Euripides was considered one of the great tragic poets of fifth-century B.C.E. Greece. While little is known about his personal life and intellectual background, we do know that he was prolific (scholars in Alexandria later attributed eighty-eight plays to him) and that he won five different tragic competitions over the course of his life. It is said that upon hearing news of Euripides' death, the famed Sophocles publicly mourned.

As Greek mythology tells it, Dionysus (also known as Bacchus) was the illegitimate offspring of Zeus (king of the gods) and Semele (a Theban princess). According to the myth, Semele's boasting of the pregnancy led Zeus's wife, Hera, and Semele's sisters to become jealous, ultimately leading Hera to kill Semele and her sisters to speak ill about Semele after her death. *The Bacchae* tells the story of the return of the hedonistic Dionysus to Thebes in order to punish Semele's sisters as well as to introduce the city to his new religion. As we join the play, the women of Thebes—including Semele's sister Agave, the daughter of former king Cadmus and mother to the present king, Pentheus—are in the throes of Dionysian ecstasy. In the ancient world, ecstatic states and behavior were associated with both religious devotion and madness, as this excerpt shows.

CHORUS: Speak to me, tell all—
How did death strike him down,
that unrighteous man,
that man who acted so unjustly?

SECOND MESSENGER: Once we'd left the settlements of Thebes,
we went across the river Asopus,
then started the climb up Mount Cithaeron—

A representation of the mythical Thracian king Lykurgos. Lykurgos, it was said, tried to prevent the spread of the Dionysian cult in his kingdom. In response, Dionysus drove the king mad; the king then killed his own son, believing him to be a vine. From Herculaneum. Museo Archeologico Nazionales, Naples, Italy. © Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY.

Pentheus and myself, I following the king.
The stranger was our guide, scouting the way.
First, we sat down in a grassy meadow,
keeping our feet and tongues quite silent,
so we could see without being noticed.
There was a valley there shut in by cliffs.
Through it refreshing waters flowed, with pines
providing shade. The Maenads sat there,
their hands all busy with delightful work—

some of them with ivy strands repairing
damaged thyrsoi, while others sang,
chanting Bacchic songs to one another,
carefree as fillies freed from harness.
Then Pentheus, that unhappy man,
not seeing the crowd of women, spoke up,
"Stranger, I can't see from where we're standing.
My eyes can't glimpse those crafty Maenads.
But up there, on that hill, a pine tree stands.
If I climbed that, I might see those women,
and witness the disgraceful things they do."
Then I saw that stranger work a marvel.
He seized that pine tree's topmost branch—
it stretched up to heaven—and brought it down,
pulling it to the dark earth, bending it
as if it were a bow or some curved wheel
forced into a circle while staked out with pegs—
that's how the stranger made that tree bend down,
forcing the mountain pine to earth by hand,
something no mortal man could ever do.
He set Pentheus in that pine tree's branches.
Then his hands released the tree, but slowly,
so it stood up straight, being very careful
not to shake Pentheus loose. So that pine
towered straight up to heaven, with my king
perched on its back. Maenads could see him there
more easily than he could spy on them.
As he was just becoming visible—
the stranger had completely disappeared—
some voice—I guess it was Dionysus—
cried out from the sky, "Young women,
I've brought you the man who laughed at you,
who ridiculed my rites. Now punish him!"
As he shouted this, a dreadful fire arose,
blazing between the earth and heaven.
The air was still. In the wooded valley
no sound came from the leaves, and all the beasts

were silent, too. The women stood up at once.
They'd heard the voice, but not distinctly.
They gazed around them. Then again the voice
shouted his commands. When Cadmus' daughters
clearly heard what Dionysus ordered,
they rushed out, running as fast as doves,
moving their feet at an amazing speed.
His mother Agave with both her sisters
and all the Bacchae charged straight through
the valley, the torrents, the mountain cliffs,
pushed to a god-inspired frenzy.
They saw the king there sitting in that pine.
First, they scaled a cliff face looming up
opposite the tree and started throwing rocks,
trying to hurt him. Others threw branches,
or hurled their thyrsoi through the air at him,
sad, miserable Pentheus, their target.
But they didn't hit him. The poor man
sat high beyond their frenzied cruelty,
trapped up there, no way to save his skin.
Then, like lightning, they struck oak branches down,
trying them as levers to uproot the tree.
When these attempts all failed, Agave said,
"Come now, make a circle round the tree.
Then, Maenads, each of you must seize a branch,
so we can catch the climbing beast up there,
stop him making our god's secret dances known."
Thousands of hands grabbed the tree and pulled.
They yanked it from the ground. Pentheus fell,
crashing to earth down from his lofty perch,
screaming in distress. He knew well enough
something dreadful was about to happen.
His priestess mother first began the slaughter.
She hurled herself at him. Pentheus tore off
his headband, untying it from his head,
so wretched Agave would recognize him,
so she wouldn't kill him. Touching her cheek,

he cried out, "It's me, mother, Pentheus,
your child. You gave birth to me at home,
in Echion's house. Pity me, mother—
don't kill your child because I've made mistakes."
But Agave was foaming at the mouth,
eyes rolling in their sockets, her mind not set
on what she ought to think—she didn't listen—
she was possessed, in a Bacchic frenzy.
She seized his left arm, below the elbow,
pushed her foot against the poor man's ribs,
then tore his shoulder out. The strength she had—
it was not her own. The god put power
into those hands of hers. Meanwhile Ino,
her sister, went at the other side,
ripping off chunks of Pentheus' flesh,
while Autonoe and all the Bacchae,
the whole crowd of them, attacked as well,
all of them howling out together.
As long as Pentheus was still alive,
he kept on screaming. The women cried in triumph—
one brandished an arm, another held a foot—
complete with hunting boot—the women's nails
tore his ribs apart. Their hands grew bloody,
tossing bits of his flesh back and forth, for fun.
His body parts lie scattered everywhere—
some under rough rocks, some in the forest,
deep in the trees. They're difficult to find.
As for the poor victim's head, his mother
stumbled on it. Her hands picked it up,
then stuck it on a thyrsus, at the tip.
Now she carries it around Cithaeron,
as though it were some wild lion's head.
She's left her sisters dancing with the Maenads.
She's coming here, inside these very walls,
showing off with pride her ill-fated prey,
calling out to her fellow hunter, Bacchus,
her companion in the chase, the winner,

the glorious victor. By serving him,
in her great triumph she wins only tears.
As for me, I'm leaving this disaster,
before Agave gets back home again.
The best thing is to keep one's mind controlled,
and worship all that comes down from the gods.
That, in my view, is the wisest custom,
for those who can conduct their lives that way.

[Exit Messenger]

CHORUS: Let's dance to honour Bacchus,
Let's shout to celebrate what's happened here,
happened to Pentheus,
child of the serpent,
who put on women's clothes,
who took up the beautiful and blessed thyrsus—
his certain death,
disaster brought on by the bull.
You Bacchic women
descended from old Cadmus,
you've won glorious victory,
one which ends in tears,
which ends in lamentation.
A noble undertaking this,
to drench one's hands in blood,
life blood dripping from one's only son.

CHORUS LEADER: Wait! I see Agave, Pentheus' mother,
on her way home, her eyes transfixed.
Let's now welcome her,
the happy revels of our god of joy!

[Enter Agave, cradling the head of Pentheus]

AGAVE: Asian Bacchae . . .

CHORUS: Why do you appeal to me?

AGAVE: *[displaying the head]* From the mountains I've brought home
this ivy tendril freshly cut.

We've had a blessed hunt.

CHORUS: I see it.
As your fellow dancer, I'll accept it.

AGAVE: I caught this young lion without a trap,
as you can see.

CHORUS: What desert was he in?

AGAVE: Cithaeron.

CHORUS: On Cithaeron?

AGAVE: Cithaeron killed him.

CHORUS: Who struck him down?

AGAVE: The honour of the first blow goes to me.
In the dancing I'm called blessed Agave.

CHORUS: Who else?

AGAVE: Well, from Cadmus . . .

CHORUS: From Cadmus what?

AGAVE: His other children laid hands on the beast,
but after me—only after I did first.
We've had good hunting. So come, share our feast.

CHORUS: What? You want me to eat that with you?
Oh you unhappy woman.

AGAVE: This is a young bull. Look at this cheek
It's just growing downy under the crop
of his soft hair.

CHORUS: His hair makes him resemble
some wild beast.

AGAVE: Bacchus is a clever huntsman—
he wisely set his Maenads on this beast.

CHORUS: Yes, our master is indeed a hunter.

AGAVE: Have you any praise for me?

CHORUS: I praise you.

AGAVE: Soon all Cadmus' people . . .

CHORUS: . . . and Pentheus, your son, as well.

AGAVE: . . . will celebrate his mother, who caught the beast,
just like a lion.

CHORUS: It's a strange trophy.

AGAVE: And strangely captured, too.

CHORUS: You're proud of what you've done?

AGAVE: Yes, I'm delighted. Great things I've done—
great things on this hunt, clear for all to see.

CHORUS: Well then, you most unfortunate woman,
show off your hunting prize, your sign of victory,
to all the citizens.

AGAVE: *[addressing everyone]* All of you here,
all you living in the land of Thebes,
in this city with its splendid walls,
come see this wild beast we hunted down—
daughters of Cadmus—not with thonged spears,
Thessalian javelins, or by using nets,
but with our own white hands, our finger tips.
After this, why should huntsmen boast aloud,
when no one needs the implements they use?
We caught this beast by hand, tore it apart—
with our own hands. But where's my father?
He should come here. And where's Pentheus?
Where is my son? He should take a ladder,
set it against the house, fix this lion's head
way up there, high on the palace front.
I've captured it and brought it home with me.

[Enter Cadmus and attendants, carrying parts of Pentheus' body]

CADMUS: Follow me, all those of you who carry
some part of wretched Pentheus. You slaves,
come here, right by the house.

[They place the bits of Pentheus' body together in a chest front of the palace]

I'm worn out.
So many searches—but I picked up the body.
I came across it in the rocky clefts
on Mount Cithaeron, ripped to pieces,
no parts lying together in one place.
It was in the woods—difficult to search.
Someone told me what my daughter'd done,
those horrific acts, once I'd come back,
returning here with old Tiresias,
inside the city walls, back from the Bacchae.
So I climbed the mountains once again.
Now I bring home this child the Maenads killed.
I saw Autonoe, who once bore
Actaeon to Aristeius—and Ino,
she was with her there, in the forest,
both still possessed, quite mad, poor creatures.
Someone said Agave was coming here,
still doing her Bacchic dance. He spoke the truth,
for I see her there—what a wretched sight!

AGAVE: Father, now you can be truly proud.
Among all living men you've produced
by far the finest daughters. I'm talking
of all of us, but especially of myself.
I've left behind my shuttle and my loom,
and risen to great things, catching wild beasts
with my bare hands. Now I've captured him,
I'm holding in my arms the finest trophy,
as you can see, bringing it back home to you,
so it may hang here.

[offering him Pentheus' head]

Take this, father
let your hands welcome it. Be proud of it,
of what I've caught. Summon all your friends—
have a banquet, for you are blessed indeed,
blessed your daughters have achieved these things.

CADMUS: This grief's beyond measure, beyond endurance.
With these hands of yours you've murdered him.
You strike down this sacrificial victim,
this offering to the gods, then invite me,
and all of Thebes, to share a banquet.
Alas—first for your sorrow, then my own.
Lord god Bromius, born into this family,
has destroyed us, acting out his justice,
but too much so.

AGAVE: Why such scowling eyes?
How sorrowful and solemn old men become.
As for my son, I hope he's a fine hunter,
who copies his mother's hunting style,
when he rides out with young men of Thebes
chasing after creatures in the wild.
The only thing he seems capable of doing
is fighting with the gods. It's up to you,
father, to reprimand him for it.
Who'll call him here into my sight,
so he can see my good luck for himself?

CADMUS: Alas! Alas! What dreadful pain you'll feel
when you recognize what you've just done.
If you stay forever in your present state,
you'll be unfortunate, but you won't feel
as if you're suffering unhappiness.

AGAVE: But what in all this is wrong or painful?

CADMUS: First, raise your eyes. Look up into the sky.

AGAVE: All right. But why tell me to look up there?

CADMUS: Does the sky still seem the same to you,
or has it changed?

AGAVE: It seems, well, brighter . . .
more translucent than it was before.

CADMUS: And your inner spirit—is it still shaking?

AGAVE: I don't understand what it is you're asking.
But my mind is starting to clear somehow.
It's changing . . . it's not what it was before.

CADMUS: Can you hear me? Can you answer clearly?

AGAVE: Yes. But, father, what we discussed before,
I've quite forgotten.

CADMUS: Then tell me this—
to whose house did you come when you got married?

AGAVE: You gave me to Echion, who, men say,
was one of those who grew from seeds you cast.

CADMUS: In that house you bore your husband a child.
What was his name?

AGAVE: His name was Pentheus.
I conceived him with his father.

CADMUS: Well then,
this head your hands are holding—whose is it?

AGAVE: It's a lion's. That's what the hunters said.

CADMUS: Inspect it carefully. You can do that
without much effort.

AGAVE: *[inspecting the head]* What is this?
What am I looking at? What am I holding?

CADMUS: Look at it. You'll understand more clearly.

AGAVE: What I see fills me with horrific pain . . .
such agony . . .

CADMUS: Does it still seem to you
to be a lion's head?

AGAVE: No. It's appalling—
this head I'm holding belongs to Pentheus.

CADMUS: Yes, that's right. I was lamenting his fate
before you recognized him.

AGAVE: Who killed him?
How did he come into my hands?

CADMUS: Harsh truth—
how you come to light at the wrong moment.

AGAVE: Tell me. My heart is pounding in me
to hear what you're about to say.

CADMUS: You killed him—
you and your sisters.

AGAVE: Where was he killed?
At home? In what sort of place?

CADMUS: He was killed
where dogs once made a common meal of Actaeon.

AGAVE: Why did this poor man go to Cithaeron?

CADMUS: He went there to ridicule the god
and you for celebrating Dionysus.

AGAVE: But how did we happen to be up there?

CADMUS: You were insane—the entire city
was in a Bacchic madness.

AGAVE: Now I see.
Dionysus has destroyed us all.

CADMUS: He took offense at being insulted.
You did not consider him a god.

AGAVE: Father, where's the body of my dearest son?

CADMUS: I had trouble tracking the body down.
I brought back what I found.

AGAVE: Are all his limbs laid out
just as they should be? And Pentheus,
what part did he play in my madness?

CADMUS: Like you, he was irreverent to the god.
That's why the god linked you and him together
in the same disaster—thus destroying
the house and me, for I've no children left,
now I see this offspring of your womb,
you unhappy woman, cruelly butchered
in the most shameful way. He was the one
who brought new vision to our family.

From Euripides, *The Bacchae*, translated by Ian Johnston, http://records.viu.ca/~johnstoi/euripides/euripides.htm. Courtesy of Ian Johnston.

Hippocrates

(ca. 460–377 B.C.E.)

Writings on Hysteria

(ca. fourth century B.C.E.)

Hippocrates was a physician from the Greek island of Cos. Along with his ancient counterpart Galen (ca. 129 C.E.–ca. 216 C.E.), his ideas and practices have shaped medicine in the Western world up to this very day. The writings attributed to him that have been passed down over the centuries, Corpus Hippocraticum, cover a range of topics, from diagnosis and prognosis to professional conduct. It is now accepted, however, that few of these documents were written by Hippocrates himself, but rather were the work of his followers.

Hippocrates' followers held that disease was the result of an imbalance within the body of fundamental fluids, referred to as "humors": blood, phlegm, and bile. Hippocratic physicians largely rejected spiritual explanations and treatments, looking instead to environmental factors, diet, and lifestyle. Inspired by Hippocrates and others, doctors for centuries after treated afflictions such as madness in an allopathic manner, that is, applying treatments designed to have the opposite effect of a given symptom. The excerpts below discuss the causes and treatment of one of the most discussed ailments in the history of madness—hysteria, considered to be primarily a female malady.

Displacement of the Womb

As for what are called women's diseases: the womb is responsible for all such diseases. For the womb, when it is displaced from its natural position, whether forward or back, causes diseases. When the neck of the womb has been moved back and does not bring its opening towards or touch the lips of the vagina, the problem is minor. But if the womb falls forward and brings its opening towards the lips, it first of all causes pain when it makes contact, and then because the womb is cut off and obstructed by the contact of its neck with the lips of the vagina, there is no so-called menstrual flow. This flow if retained causes swelling and pain. If the womb descends and is diverted so that it approaches the groin, it causes pain. If it ascends and diverted and cut off, it causes illness through its compression. When a woman is ill because of this problem, she has pains in her thighs and her head. When the womb is distended and swollen, there is no flow, and it becomes filled up. When it is filled, it touches the thighs. When the womb is filled with moisture and distended, there is no flow, and it causes pain in both the thighs and the groin, something like balls roll through the stomach, and cause pain in the head, first in one part, and then in all of it, as the disease develops.

The treatment is as follows: if the womb has only moved forward and it is possible to apply ointment, use any foul-smelling ointment you choose, either cedar or myssoton, or some other heavy and ill-scented substance, and fumigate, but do not use a vapour-bath, and do not give food or a

diuretic liquid during this time, or wash her in hot water. If the womb has turned upwards and is not obstructed, use sweet-smelling pessaries that are also inflammatory. These are myrrh, or perfume, or some other aromatic and inflammatory substance. Use these in pessaries, and from below apply fumigations with wine vapour, and wash with hot water, and use diuretics. It is clear that the womb is turned upwards and is not obstructed, because there is a flow.

If the womb is obstructed, then there is no so-called menstrual flow. This disease must be treated first with a vapour-bath; put wild figs into the wine, and heat it and put a gourd around the mouth of the vessel in which the wine is heated. Then do as follows: cut the gourd through the middle and hollow it out, and cut off a bit of its top, as if you were making a nozzle for a bellows, so that the vapour can go through its channel and reach the womb. Wash with hot water, and use pessaries made of inflammatory drugs. The following inflammatory drugs bring on menstruation: cow dung, beef bile, myrrh, alum, galbanum, and anything similar; use as much of these as possible. Evacuate from below by laxative drugs that do not cause vomiting, diluted, so that it does not become a purgative by being too strong. Use pessaries as follows, if you want them to be strong. Use half-cooked honey, and add some of the substances prescribed to bring on menstruation; after you have added them, make the pessaries like pellets used for the anus, but make them long and thin. Make the woman lie down, and elevate the feet of the bed towards her feet, insert the pessary, and apply heat either on a chamber-pot or on some other vessel, so that the pessary melts. If you want to make the pessary less strong, wrap it in linen. And if the womb is filled with fluid, with its mouth swollen, so that amenorrhoea results, heal it by bringing on menstruation with medicinal pessaries, using both inflammatory pessaries as described, as in the case of the preceding amenorrhoea. If there is an excessive flow, do not use hot water or any other kind, nor diuretics or laxative foods. Raise the foot of the bed higher, so that the inclination of the bed does not encourage the flow, and use astringent pessaries. The flow, if her period comes directly, is bloody, if it diminishes, it contains pus. Young women bleed more, and the so-called menstrual periods of older women contain more mucous.

Hysterical Suffocation

When the womb remains in the upper abdomen, the suffocation is similar to that caused by the purgative hellebore, with stiff breathing and sharp pains in the heart. Some women spit up acid saliva, and their mouths are full of fluid, and their legs become cold. In such cases, if the womb does not leave the upper abdomen directly, the women lose their voices, and their head and tongue are overcome by drowsiness. If you find such women unable to speak and with their teeth chattering, insert a pessary of wool, twisting it round the shaft of a feather in order to get it in as far as possible—dip it either in white Egyptian perfume or myrtle or bacchar or marjoram. Use a spatula to apply black medicine (the kind you use for the head) to her nostrils. If this is not available, wipe the inside of her nostrils with silphium, or insert a feather that you have dipped in vinegar, or induce sneezing. If her mouth is closed tight and she is unable to speak, make her drink castoreum in wine. Dip your finger in seal oil and wipe inside her nostrils. Insert a wool pessary, until the womb returns, and remove it when the symptoms disappear. But if, when you take the pessary out, the womb returns to the upper abdomen, insert the pessary as you did before, and apply beneath her nostrils fumigations of ground-up goat or deer horn, to which you have added hot ashes, so that they make as much smoke as possible, and have her inhale the vapour up through her nose as long as she can stand it. It is best to use a fumigation of seal oil: put the coals in a pot and wrap the woman up except for her head. So that as much vapour as possible is emitted, drip a little fat on it, and have her inhale the vapour. She should keep her mouth shut. This is the procedure if the womb has fallen upward out of place. . . .

When the womb moves towards her head and suffocation occurs in that region, the woman's head becomes heavy, though there are different symptoms in some cases. One symptom: the woman says the veins in her nose hurt her and beneath her eyes, and she becomes sleepy, and when this condition is alleviated, she foams at the mouth.

You should wash her thoroughly with hot water, and if she does not respond, with cold, from her head on down, using cool water in which you have previously boiled laurel and myrtle. Rub her head with rose perfume, and use sweet-scented fumigations beneath her vagina, but foul-scented ones at her nose. She should eat cabbage, and drink cabbage juice.

Dislocation of the Womb

If her womb moves towards her hips, her periods stop coming, and pain develops in her lower stomach and abdomen. If you touch her with your finger, you will see the mouth of the womb turned towards her hip.

When this condition occurs, wash the woman with warm water, make her eat as much garlic as she can, and have her drink undiluted sheep's milk after her meals. Then fumigate her and give her a laxative. After the laxative has taken effect, fumigate the womb once again, using a preparation of fennel and absinthe mixed together. Right after the fumigation, pull the mouth of the womb with your finger. Then insert a pessary made with squills; leave it in for a while, and then insert a pessary made with opium poppies. If you think the condition has been corrected, insert a pessary of bitter almond oil, and on the next day, a pessary of rose perfume. She should stop inserting pessaries on the first day of her period, and start again the day after it stops. The blood during the period provides a normal interruption. If there is no flow, she should drink four cantharid beetles with their legs, wings and heads removed, four dark peony seeds, cuttlefish eggs, and a little parsley seed in wine.* If she has a pain and irregular flow, she should sit in warm water, and drink honey mixed with water. If she is not cured by the first procedure, she should drink it again, until her period comes. When it comes, she should abstain from food and have intercourse with her husband. During her period she should eat mercury plant and boiled squid, and keep to soft foods. If she becomes pregnant she will be cured of this disease. . . .

When her womb moves towards her liver, she suddenly loses her voice and her teeth chatter and her colouring turns dark. This condition can occur suddenly, while she is in good health. The problem particularly affects old maids and widows—young women who have been widowed after having had children.

When this condition occurs, push your hand down below her liver, and tie a bandage below her ribs. Open her mouth and pour in very sweet-scented wine; put applications on her nostrils and burn foul-scented vapours below her womb. . . .

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*Editor's note: Lefkowitz and Fant note that in ancient times ground-up cantharid beetles were used as a diuretic as well as to induce menstruation and abortion.

Hysteria in Virgins

As a result of visions, many people choke to death, more women than men, for the nature of women is less courageous and is weaker. And virgins who do not take a husband at the appropriate time for marriage experience these visions more frequently, especially at the time of their first monthly period, although previously they have had no such bad dreams of this sort. For later the blood collects in the womb in preparation to flow out; but when the mouth of the egress is not opened up, and more blood flows into the womb on account of the body's nourishment of it and its growth, then the blood which has no place to flow out, because of its abundance, rushes up to the heart and to the lungs; and when these are filled with blood, the heart becomes sluggish, and then, because of the sluggishness, numb, and then, because of the numbness, insanity takes hold of the woman. Just as when one has been sitting for a long time the blood that has been forced away from the hips and the thighs collects in one's lower legs and feet, it brings numbness, and as a result of the numbness, one's feet are useless for movement, until the blood goes back where it belongs. It returns most quickly when one stands in cold water and wets the tops of one's ankles. This numbness presents no complications, since the blood flows back quickly because the veins in that part of the body are straight, and the legs are not a critical part of the body. But blood flows slowly from the heart and from the phrenes.* There the veins are slanted, and it is a critical place for insanity and suited for madness.

When these places are filled with blood, shivering sets in with fevers. They call these "erratic fevers." When this is the state of affairs, the girl goes crazy because of the violent inflammation, and she becomes murderous because of the decay and is afraid and fearful because of the darkness. The girls try to choke themselves because of the pressure on their hearts; their will, distraught and anguished because of the bad condition of the blood, forces evil on itself. In some cases the girl says dreadful things: [the visions] order her to jump up and throw herself into wells and drown, as if this were good for her and served some useful purpose. When a girl does not have visions, a desire sets in which compels her to love death as if it

*Editor's note: The phrenes, or diaphragm, it was believed, was where the work of mind, thought, and will resided.

were a form of good. When this person returns to her right mind, women give to Artemis various offerings, especially the most valuable of women's robes, following the orders of oracles, but they are deceived. The fact is that the disorder is cured when nothing impedes the downward flow of blood. My prescription is that when virgins experience this trouble, they should cohabit with a man as quickly as possible. If they become pregnant, they will be cured. If they don't do this, either they will succumb at the onset of puberty or a little later, unless they catch another disease. Among married women, those who are sterile are more likely to suffer what I have described.

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The Bible, Mark 5

(ca. 65–75 C.E.)

Of the four Gospels chronicling the life and teachings of Jesus of Nazareth, Mark's is considered to be the oldest. Christianity has historically had a close connection to disease and cure. Like their Jewish, Greek, and Roman predecessors and contemporaries, early and medieval Christians believed that sacred power was something that could be shared by both prophets and madmen alike. Moreover, Jesus' fame spread quickly due, in part, to stories of his alleged ability to cure a host of ailments. The story of Jesus' encounter with the Gerasene demoniac is among the most famous in the gospels. A tenth-century depiction of this scene can be found on the front cover of our volume.*

*Editor's note: Thanks to the late Bill Petersen for his suggestions and advice.

Mark 5

1 They came to the other side of the sea, to the country of the
Ger'asenes.
2 And when he had come out of the boat, there met him out of the
tombs a man with an unclean spirit,
3 who lived among the tombs; and no one could bind him any more,
even with a chain;
4 for he had often been bound with fetters and chains, but the chains he
wrenched apart, and the fetters he broke in pieces; and no one had the
strength to subdue him.
5 Night and day among the tombs and on the mountains he was always
crying out, and bruising himself with stones.
6 And when he saw Jesus from afar, he ran and worshiped him;
7 and crying out with a loud voice, he said, "What have you to do with
me, Jesus, Son of the Most High God? I adjure you by God, do not tor-
ment me."
8 For he had said to him, "Come out of the man, you unclean spirit!"
9 And Jesus asked him, "What is your name?" He replied, "My name is
Legion; for we are many."
10 And he begged him eagerly not to send them out of the country.
11 Now a great herd of swine was feeding there on the hillside;
12 and they begged him, "Send us to the swine, let us enter them."
13 So he gave them leave. And the unclean spirits came out, and entered
the swine; and the herd, numbering about two thousand, rushed down
the steep bank into the sea, and were drowned in the sea.
14 The herdsmen fled, and told it in the city and in the country. And
people came to see what it was that had happened.
15 And they came to Jesus, and saw the demoniac sitting there, clothed
and in his right mind, the man who had had the legion; and they were
afraid.
16 And those who had seen it told what had happened to the demoniac
and to the swine.
17 And they began to beg Jesus to depart from their neighborhood.
18 And as he was getting into the boat, the man who had been possessed
with demons begged him that he might be with him.
19 But he refused, and said to him, "Go home to your friends, and tell

them how much the Lord has done for you, and how he has had mercy
on you."
20 And he went away and began to proclaim in the Decap'olis how much
Jesus had done for him; and all men marveled.
21 And when Jesus had crossed again in the boat to the other side, a great
crowd gathered about him; and he was beside the sea.
22 Then came one of the rulers of the synagogue, Ja'irus by name; and
seeing him, he fell at his feet,
23 and besought him, saying, "My little daughter is at the point of death.
Come and lay your hands on her, so that she may be made well, and live."
24 And he went with him. And a great crowd followed him and thronged
about him.
25 And there was a woman who had had a flow of blood for twelve years,
26 and who had suffered much under many physicians, and had spent all
that she had, and was no better but rather grew worse.
27 She had heard the reports about Jesus, and came up behind him in the
crowd and touched his garment.
28 For she said, "If I touch even his garments, I shall be made well."
29 And immediately the hemorrhage ceased; and she felt in her body that
she was healed of her disease.
30 And Jesus, perceiving in himself that power had gone forth from him,
immediately turned about in the crowd, and said, "Who touched my
garments?"
31 And his disciples said to him, "You see the crowd pressing around you,
and yet you say, 'Who touched me?'"
32 And he looked around to see who had done it.
33 But the woman, knowing what had been done to her, came in fear and
trembling and fell down before him, and told him the whole truth.
34 And he said to her, "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in
peace, and be healed of your disease."
35 While he was still speaking, there came from the ruler's house some
who said, "Your daughter is dead. Why trouble the Teacher any fur-
ther?"
36 But ignoring what they said, Jesus said to the ruler of the synagogue,
"Do not fear, only believe."
37 And he allowed no one to follow him except Peter and James and John
the brother of James.

38 When they came to the house of the ruler of the synagogue, he saw a tumult, and people weeping and wailing loudly.
39 And when he had entered, he said to them, "Why do you make a tumult and weep? The child is not dead but sleeping."
40 And they laughed at him. But he put them all outside, and took the child's father and mother and those who were with him, and went in where the child was.
41 Taking her by the hand he said to her, "Tal'itha cu'mi," which means, "Little girl, I say to you, arise."
42 And immediately the girl got up and walked (she was twelve years of age), and they were immediately overcome with amazement.
43 And he strictly charged them that no one should know this, and told them to give her something to eat.

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Soranus of Ephesus

(ca. second century C.E.)

"Madness or Insanity (Greek Mania)"

Soranus of Ephesus studied medicine in Alexandria and practiced in Rome during the reigns of the emperors Trajan and Hadrian. Particularly famous for his treatise on gynecology, he was the author of many works, and, along with Hippocrates and Galen, his teachings influenced Western medicine well into the Middle Ages. Soranus was a proponent of a school of medicine known as Methodism, which tended to see the body as composed of moving atoms—as opposed to flowing humors, as the Hippocratic school viewed it—and held that abnormalities in the movements

of these atoms caused disease. The excerpt here comes from a treatise titled *On Chronic Diseases*. The original text has been lost, but a reliable Latin translation by the physician Caelius Aurelianus (ca. early fifth century C.E.) provides us with valuable insight into not only the beside manner of the Methodist doctor, but also experiences and understandings of madness in the Roman Empire.

Madness or Insanity (Greek Mania)

In the *Phaedrus*, Plato declares that there are two kinds of mania, one involving a mental strain that arises from a bodily cause of origin, the other divine or inspired, with Apollo as the source of the inspiration. This latter kind, he says, is now called "divination," but in early times was called "madness"; that is, the Greeks now call it "prophetic inspiration" (*mantice*), though in remote antiquity it was called "mania." Plato goes on to say that another kind of divine mania is sent by Father Bacchus, that still another, called "erotic inspiration," is sent by the god of love, and that a fourth kind comes from the Muses and is called "protreptic inspiration" because it seems to inspire men to song. The Stoics also say that madness is of two kinds, but they hold that one kind consists in lack of wisdom, so that they can consider every imprudent person mad; the other kind, they say, involves a loss of reason and a concomitant bodily affection. The school of Empedocles holds that one form of madness consists in a purification of the soul, and the other in an impairment of the reason resulting from a bodily disease or indisposition.

It is this latter form of madness that we shall now consider. The Greeks call it *mania* because it produces great mental anguish (Greek *ania*); or else because there is excessive relaxing of the soul or mind, the Greek word for "relaxed" or "loose" being *manos*; or because the disease defiles the patient, the Greek word "to defile" being *lymaenin*; or because it makes the patient desirous of being alone and in solitude, the Greek word "to be bereft" and "to seek solitude" being *monusthae*; or because the disease holds the body tenaciously and is not easily shaken off, the Greek word for "persistence" being *monia*; or because it makes the patient hard and enduring (Greek *hypomeneticos*).

Mania is an impairment of reason; it is chronic and without fever and in these respects may be distinguished from phrenitis. For mania is not an acute disease, nor is it observed to occur with fever; or, if fever *is* present in case of mania, the case may be distinguished from phrenitis by considerations of time, for in mania the madness precedes any supervening fever and the patient does not have a small pulse. In phrenitis, however, the fever always precedes the madness, and the patient has a small pulse.

Mania occurs more frequently in young and middle-aged men, rarely in old men, and most infrequently in children and women. Sometimes it strikes suddenly, at other times it takes hold gradually. Sometimes it arises from hidden causes, at other times from observable causes, such as exposure to intense heat, the taking of severe cold, indigestion, frequent and uncontrolled drunkenness (Greek *craepale*), continual sleeplessness, excesses of venery, anger, grief, anxiety, or superstitious fear, a shock or blow, intense straining of the sense and the mind in study, business, or other ambitious pursuits, the drinking of drugs, especially of those intended to excite love (Greek *philtropota*), the removal of long-standing hemorrhoids or varices, and, finally, the suppression of the menses in women.

Before the disease emerges, those who are not attacked suddenly by it have the same symptoms as persons on the verge of epilepsy or of apoplexy. These signs may be found, then, in what has already been said. But some seek to distinguish the antecedent signs of these diseases by listing specific signs for each of them in addition to the general signs common to all. Thus deep sleep, they say, is indicative of the coming of epilepsy; light and short sleep, on the other hand, of mania. So, too, they take it as an indication that mania is imminent when a person in a state of anger suffers congestion of the head and believes that he has gone mad or, again, when such a person is overcome by speechlessness resulting from groundless fear. Other such signs, in their opinion, are unhappiness, mental anxiety, tossing in sleep, immoderate appetite, frequent blinking of the eyes, palpitation of the heart, sleep marked by great fear and turmoil, abdominal distention, frequent passing of wind through the anus, and a small, rapid, hard pulse. On the other hand, they say that persons on the verge of epilepsy have a large, rare, and soft pulse. Now these same writers tell us to study the nature of these diseases as they first come to the body, on the theory that they often attack the body by a kind of external contact. But all these methods fail, in our

opinion, to provide an accurate and definite means of distinguishing which of the aforesaid diseases is imminent in a given case. . . .

Now when the disease of mania emerges into the open, there is impairment of reason unaccompanied by fever; this impairment of reason in some cases is severe, in others mild; it differs in various cases in its outward form and appearance, though its nature and character are the same. For, when mania lays hold of the mind, it manifests itself now in anger, now in merriment, now in sadness or futility, and now, as some related, in an overpowering fear of things which are quite harmless. Thus the patient will be afraid of caves or will be obsessed by the fear of falling into a ditch or will dread other things which may for some reason inspire fear.

The ancients also associated madness with a kind of prophetic power. And Demetrius calls mania a strain imposed on the mind for a brief period, saying that some persons in a sudden moment of confusion are so terror-stricken that they lose their memory of the past. In fact, Apollonius tells us that when the philologist Artemidorus was lying on the sand he was frightened by the ponderous approach of a crocodile; his mind was so affected by the sudden sight of the reptile's motion that he imagined that his left leg and hand had been eaten by the animal, and he lost his memory even of literature. Apollonius says that melancholy should be considered a form of mania, but we distinguish melancholy from mania. And mania or madness is sometimes continuous and other times relieved by intervals of remission. Thus the patient sometimes does not remember his tasks, sometimes is unaware of his own forgetfulness, sometimes suffers impairment of all the senses, and sometimes is affected by various other types of aberration. Thus one victim of madness fancied himself a sparrow, another a cock, another an earthen vessel, another a brick, another a god, another an orator, another a tragic actor, another a comic actor, another a stalk of grain and asserted that he occupied the center of the universe, and another cried like a baby and begged to be carried in the arms. In most cases of mania, at the time of the actual attack, the eyes become bloodshot and intent. There is also continual wakefulness, the veins are distended, cheeks flushed, and body hard and abnormally strong.

In this disease the whole system of nerves and sinews is affected, as we may gather from the symptoms. But the head is especially affected; and, in fact, most of the discomfort preceding the attack is in the head, the patient being affected by a feeling of pain and heaviness there. Also the senses are

individually affected, and these are, as we know, centered in the head. Mania is a major disease; it is chronic and consists of attacks alternating with periods of remission; it involves a state of stricture. . . . Thus, in the interval of remission the patient feels fatigued. Our conclusion is further confirmed by the symptoms that precede the loss of reason, e.g., a feeling of heaviness in the head, pain in the spine and shoulder blades, sluggishness in the movements of the limbs, and abdominal distention. Thus those who imagine that the disease is chiefly an affection of the soul and only secondarily of the body are mistaken. For no philosopher has ever set forth a successful treatment for this disease; moreover, before the mind is affected, the body itself shows visible symptoms. This concludes the Methodist account of the recognition or diagnosis of the disease.

As for the treatment, we hold that measures should be taken similar to those employed in epilepsy. Thus, to begin with, have the patient lie in a moderately light and warm room. The room should be perfectly quiet, unadorned by paintings, not lighted by low windows, and on the ground floor rather than on the upper stories, for victims of mania have often jumped out of windows. And the bed should be firmly fastened down. It should face away from the entrance to the room so that the patient will not see those who enter. In this way the danger of exciting or aggravating his madness by letting him see many different faces will be avoided. And the bedclothes should be soft.

Rub the patient's limbs and hold them gently. If any part of the body is shaken by a throbbing movement, relieve it with warmth, applying soft scoured wool to the head, too, the neck and circularly to the chest. Also employ a fomentation of warm olive oil, sometimes adding, for its soothing properties, fenugreek water (obtained from a decoction of fenugreek; but see that it is not thick), or else an infusion of marsh mallow or flaxseed. Then wash the patient's mouth and have him take a drink of warm water.

Do not permit many people, especially strangers, to enter the room. And instruct servants to correct the patient's aberrations while giving them a sympathetic hearing. That is, have the servants, on the one hand, avoid the mistake of agreeing with everything the patient says, corroborating all his fantasies, and thus increasing his mania; and, on the other hand, have them avoid the mistake of objecting to everything he says and thus aggravating the severity of the attack. . . .

If the patient is excited when he sees people, bind him without doing any injury. First cover his limbs with wool and then fasten with a bandage. Now if there is a person whom the patient has customarily feared or respected, he should not be brought into the sickroom repeatedly. For this frequent repetition gives rise to a lack of regard. But when circumstances require it, as when the patient does not submit to the application of a remedy, this person should then be brought in to overcome the patient's stubbornness, by inspiring fear or respect. And if you observe that the light is upsetting his mind, shade his eyes but let the rest of his body be touched by the light.

Do not give the patient food until the end of the first three-day period; and if his strength permits and the disease requires it, perform venesection before the end of the three-day period. If there is any reason why an adequate withdrawal of blood cannot be made, take the amount required in several operations. But if there is no reason for doing otherwise, perform the venesection at the end of the three-day period.

After venesection anoint the patient, foment his face, and give him a small quantity of light and digestible food, e.g., bread in warm water, spelt groats mixed with honey which has been boiled down moderately, and some other gruel-like or soft food. Thereafter, feed the patient on alternate days, if his strength permits, until the disease declines. And if the case requires it, purge with a simple clyster. Again, relax the precordial region with poultices as an aid to digestion. The purpose is to prevent any state of constriction from causing the pent-up gases to pass to the head. Attention must also be paid to the type of mental aberration involved, for its symptoms will have to be relieved by properly reasonable countermeasures. Thus they [the servants] will soothe a patient with cheerfulness, telling him something to relax his mind.

And when the highest stage of the attack is reached, cut the patient's hair and shave his head; then apply cupping with scarification, beginning with the precordia, and then passing to the region between the shoulder blades (Greek *metaphrenon*). For in these cases the upper parts of the body are apt to be sympathetically affected. Then apply cupping in conjunction with scarification to the occiput, the top of the head, and the temples. And if the face is particularly affected, relax the whole body using leeches, which we call *hirudines*. Then use poultices of bread and other substances with relaxing properties, followed by an application of heat with sponges. And if

the disease persists, keep using the same remedies a second or even a third time. If the patient is wakeful, prescribe passive exercise, first in a hammock and then in a sedan chair. The rapid dripping of water may be employed to induce sleep, for under the influence of its sound patients often fall asleep. And heat should then be applied to the eyes with warm sponges, and the stiffness of the lids relaxed; for the beneficial effects of this treatment will pass through the eyes to the membranes of the brain.

When the disease declines and the patient's wakefulness and mental aberration are very much reduced, give him varied food of the middle class. . . . And then prescribe passive exercise, first in a sedan chair and then in a cart drawn by hand. When the patient's body has gained strength, prescribe walking and also vocal exercise, as required by the case. Thus have the patient read aloud even from texts that are marred by false statements. In this way he will exercise his mind more thoroughly. And for the same reason he should also be kept busy answering questions. This will enable us both to detect malingering and to obtain the information we require. Then let him relax, giving him reading that is easy to understand; injury due to overexertion will thus be avoided. For if these mental exercises overtax the patient's strength, they are no less harmful than passive exercise carried to excess.

And so after the reading let him see a stage performance. A mime is suitable if the patient's madness has not manifested itself in dejection; on the other hand, a composition depicting sadness or tragic error is suitable in cases of madness which involve childish playfulness. For the particular characteristic of a case of mental disturbance must be corrected by emphasizing the opposite quality, so that the mental condition, too, may attain the balanced state of health. And as the treatment proceeds, have the patient deliver discourses or speeches, as far as his strength permits. And in this case the speeches should all be arranged in the same way, the introduction to be delivered with a gentle voice, the narrative portions and proof more loudly and intensely, and the conclusion, again, in a subdued and kindly manner. This is in accordance with the precepts of those who have written on vocal exercise (Greek *anaphonesis*). An audience should be present, consisting of persons familiar to the patient; by according the speech favorable attention and praise, they will help relax the speaker's mind. And, in fact, any pleasant bodily exercise promotes the general health. Soon after the discourse or speech, the patient should be taken and gently anointed; he

should then take a light walk for exercise.

Now if he is unacquainted with literature, give him problems appropriate to his particular craft, e.g., agricultural problems if he is a farmer, problems in navigation if he is a pilot. And if he is without any skill whatever, give him questions on commonplace matters, or let him play checkers. Such a game can exercise his mind, particularly if he plays with a more experienced opponent. . . .

Serve the patient varied food, as we indicated above in discussing epilepsy. Do not give him wine at first, but add some fruit to his diet to test the body. Afterward give him a small quantity of thin, mild wine at the time of eating. At first, the wine should be given at intervals of five days, and, as times goes on, at intervals of four, three, two, and then on alternate days; finally, it maybe be given every day. But water should be drunk in the intervals, the amount decreasing in proportion as the allotment of wine becomes more liberal.

Then, if the patient shows no new symptoms and has accustomed himself to the various parts of his regimen, change of climate should be prescribed. And if he is willing to hear discussion of philosophers, he should be afforded the opportunity. For by their words philosophers help to banish fear, sorrow, and wrath, and in so doing make no small contribution to the health of the body.

But if the disease persists and becomes chronic, being marked by attacks alternating with intervals of remission, relieve the attacks using the same remedies as those prescribed above for the initial attack of mania. But in the intervals of remission, prescribe, first, the restorative series of treatments including various types of passive exercise, vocal exercise arranged under supervision of a musician, walking, passive exercise, varied food, and the like. Follow this series with the metasyncritic cycle, as we have described it above.

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